



IN 2003, WHEN a wide-eyed Aparna Purohit, then in her early twenties, started working on a film set, some of her dreams had come true. But she soon realised others would take their own sweet time to fructify.

Back then, some film sets didn't even have basic facilities like toilets or changing rooms for women, and Purohit—who's survived all this and worse—stands tall today as the Head of India and Southeast Asia Originals at Amazon Prime Video to tell that often harrowing tale. "I recollect being on an outdoor shoot once where the actress and I were the only women in the crew. There were no facilities; no toilets or changing rooms in a remote outdoor location—and demanding basic rights got us labelled as 'difficult to work with,'" she recalls. She says the only way out is to speak up.

"As I grew in my career, these were some of the things that I looked into as priorities. I want to make sure that women are not easily dismissed and don't go through such experiences as they find their foothold in this industry," she says.

Sure, India's entertainment industry has come a long way from when Purohit was starting out. Directors like Zoya Akhtar, producers like Guneet Monga Kapoor, writers like Juhi Chaturvedi, cinematographers like Fowzia Fathima and editors like Aarti Bajaj were few and far between. Women in India's entertainment sector believe that while the industry has come a long way over the years, it's still a long, long way away from equality, especially in terms of leadership roles.

SORRY STATE

According to a recent report, called 'O Womaniya!', by consulting firm Ormax Media, entertainment platform Film Companion, and OTT platform Amazon Prime Video, only 12 per cent of the 780 HOD (head of department) positions analysed across key departments of direction, cinematography, editing, writing, and production design were held by women. It's interesting to note that the share of female HODs increased

Narrative Shift



Traditionally, women have faced significant barriers in the media and entertainment (M&E) industry



This includes gender bias, limited opportunities, stereotypes in storytelling, and workplace harassment



The industry has come a long way with directors like Zoya Akhtar, producers like Guneet Monga Kapoor, writers like Juhi Chaturvedi, and cinematographers like Fowzia Fathima



But a lot still needs to change. A recent report found that only 12 per cent of the 780 head of department positions were held by women



Streaming, rather than theatrical films, continues to pave the way for female representation, the report reveals



Women believe affirmative action is a good start when it comes to increasing women's presence in key creative roles

from 17 per cent in 2021 to 22 per cent in 2022 in content when women were in charge of commissioning, but fell from 8 per cent to 7 per cent when a man was in charge of commissioning. "This data highlights an important point: women in leadership positions are actively hiring more women. This trend underscores the pivotal role played by women in shaping the industry's diversity landscape by actively promoting the inclusion of female talent in important creative positions," says Purohit.

Traditionally, women have faced significant barriers in the media and entertainment (M&E) industry, including gender bias, limited access to opportunities, stereotypes in storytelling, and workplace harassment. Such long-standing issues that have persisted for de-